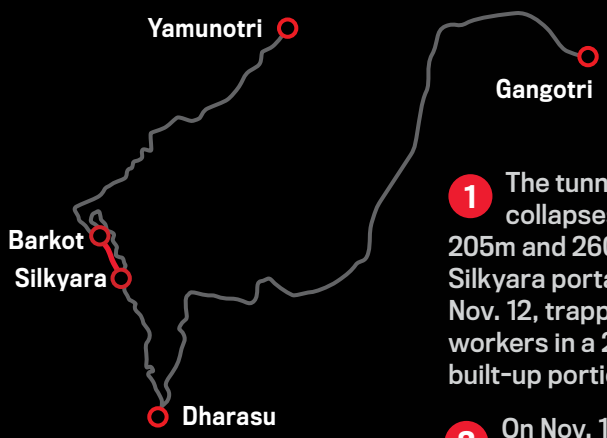
How They Did It

Surmounting all odds, multiple men and agencies worked tirelessly for over 400 hours to rescue the 41 trapped workers from a collapsed tunnel in Uttarakhand

Graphic by NILANJAN DAS



ABOUT THE TUNNEL

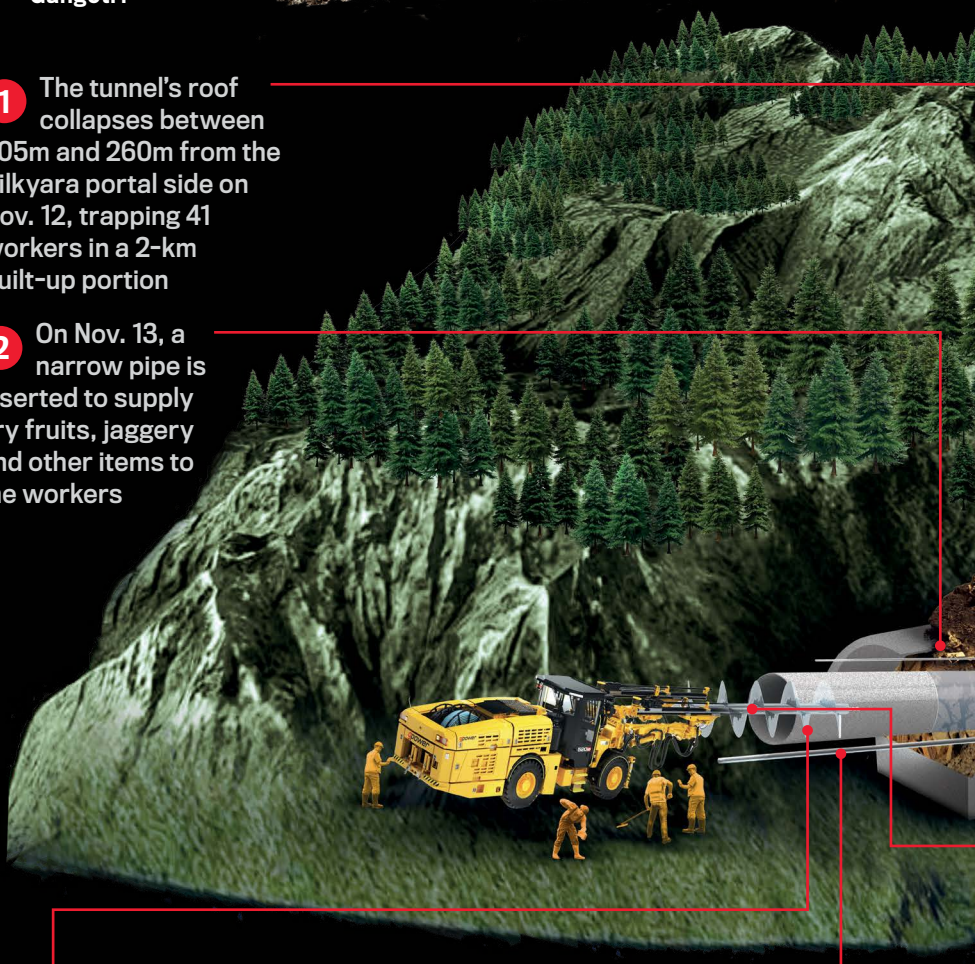
- The 4.5-km Silkyara-Barkot tunnel will provide all-weather connectivity between Gangotri and Yamunotri under the Radi pass, as part of the Char Dham Highway Development Project
- It will effectively reduce the 25.6-km snow-affected stretch of NH-134 (Dharasu-Barkot-Yamunotri road) to 4.5 km, resulting in a travel time of just 5 minutes, a tenth of the 50 minutes that it takes to cover the distance at present
- Before the collapse, 56 per cent of the project was completed, with May 14, 2024, as the deadline. The new deadline is yet to be announced

8 On Nov. 27, rat-hole miners are deployed to crawl through the main rescue tunnel to cut free the auger's rotor that got entangled with the lattice girder bars. By the Nov. 28 afternoon, only two metres of manual drilling is left, which they complete by the evening



1 The tunnel's roof collapses between 205m and 260m from the Silkyara portal side on Nov. 12, trapping 41 workers in a 2-km built-up portion

2 On Nov. 13, a narrow pipe is inserted to supply dry fruits, jaggery and other items to the workers



3 On Nov. 14, steel pipes of about 1m diameter inserted through the rubble to create a 60m rescue tunnel from the Silkyara portal with the help of an auger machine for horizontal drilling. Over the next week, better drilling equipment is flown in to expedite the operation

4 On Nov. 21, a pipe of 150mm diameter inserted to supply freshly cooked food, fruits, medicines and other essentials. A camera is sent through, which relays the first visuals of the workers